



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 16

INDIANA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Indiana's family courts and child-welfare system.

57

INDIANA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 68
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 6 MONTHS
MEDIAN TIME IN SYSTEM

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 24, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
10 OF 92

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

INDIANA AT A GLANCE.

Across 57 Indiana families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 68 57 of 57 families reporting with kids	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$5,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 6 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 43.9% 28.1% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 57	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.2	REPORTING FAMILIES 57 of 57	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 10

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Indiana families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF INDIANA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	57	\$5,000	\$24,044	\$1,370,500
Lost Wages	57	\$300	\$51,102	\$2,912,801
Other Court Fees	57	\$0	\$698	\$39,800
Therapy / Evaluations	57	\$0	\$6,109	\$348,200
Reunification Services	57	\$0	\$680	\$38,750
GAL Fees	57	\$0	\$2,749	\$156,700
Asset Loss ¹	57	\$0	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$5,300	—	—

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$0) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS



03 WHO IS REPORTING · INDIANA

Most families documenting in Indiana are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Currently involved / "S...		24	42%
Case closed (within th...		15	26%
Unknown		13	23%
Case closed (more tha...		3	5%
I was a Child of Family...		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and ...		24	42%
Family Court Only		19	33%
CPS (Child Protective ...		10	18%
Unknown		4	7%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		18	32%
6 months – 1 year		8	14%
5 – 10 years		7	12%
3 – 5 years		7	12%
Over 10 years		6	11%

CUSTODY STATUS

Visitation Only		16	28%
No Contact / Total Los...		12	21%
50/50 Joint		8	14%
Full Custody		7	12%
Adopted Out (Rights Te...		6	11%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Unknown		13	23%
Marion		6	11%
Allen		3	5%
Hamilton		3	5%
Delaware		3	5%
Cass		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Ac...		15	26%
Other: (Short answer)		11	19%
False Accusations CPS...		7	12%
High Conflict Divorce		7	12%
Family Court		3	5%

05 PARENT VOICES — INDIANA

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



Trauma PTSD due to removal all 5 children and my self major depression and my 5 year old is a self harmer. They destroyed a beautiful family left us in ruins.

— NICHOLE

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

Ex used old therapy messages without disclosing to opposing counsel as evidence of substance abuse, but there weren't any. I took 2 90 day hair follicle tests to debunk his allegations, and the judge seemed to just ignore my proof. Daughter complained of her grandmother abusing [...]

— INDIANA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM INDIANA

Procedural failures and biased reporting—especially in documentation—led to a narrative that misrepresented me and negatively impacted my family. Instead of protecting stability, the system introduced confusion, delay, and unnecessary harm. The process became more about [...]

— EVA

It's destroyed me and my children and the bond we had

— JAMIE

Destroyed it & then caused same harm on 2 of the kids they wanted to blame me for.

— AMY

Destroyed us caused alot of issues had to quit my job to homeschool my kids they were trying their hardest to take my kids from me for no reason

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

These people have tore my kids away from loving parents only to scuritize and defamate me and my wife

— BRANDON

Through the CHINS process, DCS has not only disrupted our family but has inflicted lasting emotional, spiritual, and financial strain, challenging our rights as parents and our ability to nurture our children in a safe, loving, and faith-centered environment

— KARI

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



DESTROYED IT, my son doesn't even respond to myself or his grandparents and any of my family

— CHRISTOPHER

They stole my 3 kids and lied about it. Adopted them out.

— RALPH

Traumatized us. Let an abusive sadistic man maintain control.

— KIM

The info I provided is just the tip of the ice berg. There is so much more. We have been ripped apart as a family. Little sisters once close torn apart never to see each other again. We are traumatized. Depressed. No one cares. No one will listen. No one will help.

— CRYSTAL

Destroyed my family and our future. My son isn't the same . Ruined my credit my reputation tried to cost me my retirement even.

— KATRINA

Traumatized, isolated my child from family.

— CHASITY

destroyed us made us resent eachother and the system went into deep depression made us spiral downhill since hearing

— JENNIFER

They kidnapped 3 of my granddaughters, traumatized them and adopted 2 of them out, and gave the baby back after a year and a half. The 6 year old does not understand why she got adopted but her baby sister got to come home. They ripped our family apart.

— JOYCE

Dehumanized, tortured, and killed us all.

— TRISTA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Traumatized us after the first round they were at our house on allocations called in an anonymously. They had 28 and substantiated calls in between both cases. It was like we were harassed at least once a month. We were scared to let kids play and get normal bumps and bruises [...]

— TERESSA

Separated my children and caused them to have emotional issues

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Shattered completely. Girls fear punishment for association....even tho they grown. Dad is money supply.

— SHELBY

Completely destroyed it

— KATRINA

The system stole my entire soul from me, my first baby, the little girl who made me a mom. And gave my abuser power through lies and manipulation.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Turned my kids against me.

— LIZA

Robbed us of our rely and memories. Broken out bond and ruined out emotional and mental health effects our future relationships.

— SUZI

Indiana dcs has robbed my children of what could have been a happy, normal childhood and rendered us gagged, bound, helpless and alone. The only protection my children needed was from the Department of Child Services.

— EMILY

Made things worse then what they were

— CASEY

This system is failling to protect a little girl who simply does not have a voice. While simultaneously encouraging our abuser to sabotage a future before its even started. My daughter just turned 3 and a half.

— ISAAC

It has changed me on a molecular level, I am sicker now than I ever have been and I'm watching my children misunderstood why their mother isn't present like she was.

— KAYLE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Took away my rights as a mother time away from my son time spending with him cost me thousands asking the same thing over and over again.chose an abusive parent that now has custody.

— AMBER

The system showed me that the court system as a whole is extensively flawed. The system is a popularity contest of who knows who; not justice.

— MARRINA

Inflicted nothing but harm, pain, and ensured future issues to be processed in the future. This system torn us part for no known reason and continues to steal money from my family while boosting the growing three million the state makes from support.

— JIM

The family court system has allowed my ex to abuse me post-separation via expensive litigation, delaying necessary services for our son who is struggling and has ignored every piece of evidence brought into the court room. The system has failed my child.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ruined my family, deprived me of my rights and taught me that money talks more than the truth. It has taught me that under civil law there is no right to counsel as there is under criminal law.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

It put me through mental and emotional hell.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I have lost precious time with my child because of delays and negligence. Numerous hearings ignored for me and granted for ex wife that cost my relationship with my son unmeasurably.

— JEFF

It is a well-documented systematic network of people profiting off perpetuating the endless nightmare of abuse from my ex-husband and aiding in the slow public murder of myself and family.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Make me take parenting classes, sych. Test, on probation, threatening me with jail, take all my money. I have deep depression to the point of thinking about suicide

— ANTHONY

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Taken so much precious time my kids lost with me that we can never get back. Scarred the kids in seeing that the courts truly did not care about their best interest and let us down over and over.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I lost primary custody without my full evidence being presented, missed two weeks of work and had to file for short-term disability, and my reputation has been deeply impacted—all while trying to protect and support my child.

— MACY

Created diversion, chaos, and emotionally trashed my family, sat back and watched the diversion they created... And used it for their own financial gain.

— MICHAEL

It has completely made distrust with the system, the law is scared of the word family law. Allen County is a County where people help the abuse. My son's dad was allowed to come after my daughters. Everyone keeps saying this doesn't involve them. But the hurt and loss of losing [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

41 Indiana parents submitted ranked quotes. 41 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/in.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Indiana report comes from Indiana respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Indiana — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 57 Indiana families reporting here are not the universe of Indiana families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics (email + name + submission date) are applied before aggregation. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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